of this anti-corruption movement only goes to show that the youth are not necessarily attracted to young leaders as much as they are to young ideas.

Anna's status as a political outsider added most to his credibility. The young saw the establishment packed with corrupt deal makers and breakers and they wanted no part of it. The anti-corruption movement did not allow any politician on the stage with Anna, yet other notables, from Aamir Khan to Sri Sri Ravishankar, were greeted warmly. Though Anna and the front, India Against Corruption, kept politicians out, every political party, barring the Congress, wanted to be included as sympathiser. From the Left, the CPI (M), and from the Right, the BJP, did everything besides sending Hallmark cards, to draw Anna's attention.

For the record, it must be mentioned that the Imam of Jama Masjid stayed unimpressed. His opposition was swiftly neutered by other organisations like the Ulema Council, Jamaat-e-Islami Hind and the All India Muslim Women's Personal Law Board. All of them criticised Imam Bukhari and found nothing wrong with the cries of Bharat Mata routinely belted out by Anna's followers. It was this combination of parties and organisations behind Anna that induced many "politically correct" people to re-think. The flag-waving and the fervent cries of Bharat Mata that hung like a noisy aerosol over the Ramlila grounds did not arouse in them feelings of disdain as they did in the past. Instead, they signalled a positive bonding with no angularities attached.

Anna was bewildered by the support he received, and that too in the national capital. He came with a reputation of honesty, but so many honest people have slipped into oblivion. Yet, boisterous, happy crowds cling-wrapped him everywhere. A worried government eventually agreed to Anna's conditions in the hope that he would give up his fast, which was threatening his health. The demands Anna set forth were non-partisan and aimed only at corruption: a citizens' charter, Lok Ayukta in every state and to include upper deck bureaucrats in the ambit of Lokpal inquiries.

Anna won that battle and at that very instant also lost the war: another paradox. When he gave up his fast at Ramlila grounds, he also let it be known that he would weigh in for the Opposition in the coming general election. At exactly that point, as if a giant switch was turned off, Anna's charisma dimmed and blacked out. From a moral crusader, he had become a political animal in an instant. This was confirmed when, soon after, in December he sat with political leaders in Jantar Mantar in happy camaraderie. Collectively, they dreamt prospects at the hustings in an atmosphere of smiling lips and stern calculating eyes.

Anna still did not know that his charisma had fused and set out to recreate the Ramlila magic in Mumbai. It was a disaster. Only a handful turned up and row upon row of chairs stared emptily into media cameras. When Anna became political, the youth were no longer interested in him. Anna's special quality was gone, for at the political plane the youth had many other choices. Anna's movement was now officially dead and his supporters fractionated along political lines. Lokpals, the citizen's charter were words whose meanings were gradually getting difficult to recall. The real world was back!

When Anna became political, the youth were no longer interested in him...his special quality was gone and they had many other choices

Just as crayoned skies end the day, youth bring colour to a movement before fading into the night. Such mobilisations are invariably fleeting moments for a number of reasons. First, people stay young for a very brief window and, except for a few laggards, they invariably succeed in clambering over it. Second, the next generation of young hate inheriting a cause; they would rather start one of their own. This is true around the world: the beatniks gave way to the mods, rockers, hippies, yippies, punks, and so on. Ironically, if there is any inheritance at all, it travels in the reverse direction. Those with wizened looks and calculating minds take over and convert a young passion into a bureaucratic programme. What was once a movement soon becomes a party and, true to form, the iron law of oligarchy and the rule of experts take over. The youth that still remain, on this side of that narrow window, are now a bother, if not an embarrassment. Every generation must make that same futile mistake. ■

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